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Sloppy Joe's - The Writers' Vote[Jeff Cunningham](#)

3/8/2005

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There is nothing worse than sloppy Magic.

You know what I mean.

Ten schoolkids playing multiplayer with two-hundred card decks at lunchtime, mustard and cookie-grit grinding into the cards. Or two guys playing a draft game on a picnic table on windy day, and one guy has three [Wellwishers](#), and the other has out a [Mobilization](#) and a Mana [Flare](#). Or one of those six on six survivor-draft at 5am, as the Pro Tour site is closing. It's disgusting, count me out. I like to play Magic neatly.



The writer's vote for the 2005 Magic Invitational is a sloppy one.

It's called the Writer's Vote, but we're not voting for writers, we're just voting for people with talent and personality. However, most writers fall into that category, so there's a lot of messy crossover.

So you've got sixteen people choosing from a truly mixed-bag of seventeen. Half of the people voting are on the list of potential candidates, and it's legal to vote for yourself. We don't just get one vote each, we get five, and each vote is worth a different amount. This convoluted system is especially mind-boggling compared to the elegance of the fifteen other votes for the invitational. This vote is where the leftovers went. This is the sloppy vote.

In an effort to preserve the integrity of the Invitational, I decided to interpret this mess of a category as follows. People who deserve the spot, people who write; the unsung heroes of the Pro Tour. The Internet Writer's vote ought to be won by a writer, no matter what personality/talent pigeonhole category they're trying to dovetail it with.

Anyway, that said, here's what I came up with. I am not playing politics, and I'm talkin' from the heart. Bear with me for some rare moments of sincerity.

First of all, honorable mention to Paul Rietzl, a perennial money-draft partner whose single report utilized the word 'toothless' with such frequency and with such remarkable grace that it almost earned him a top spot in and of itself.

5. Jeroen Remie

For his contributions to Brainburst.com, articles always written with earnestness.

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Because he won a Pro Tour this year.

Because he would take the tournament seriously. (ie. because he WOULDN'T make a penguin.)

Because he still plays Magic, a lot.

Because under his elbow it smells like peaches.

This point's for your Jeroen. And all the things you do.

4. Osyp Lebedowycz

Because his reports are funny, concise and brutal. Take this line, 'Lucas is a good guy and I had no problem losing to him. It's too bad he made a blunder in the finals to lose the GP though. I heard that after the GP was over; Lucas was seen walking around the site in disbelief with his pants around his ankles.'

Anyway, he's already in so no need to talk him up.

3. Tim Aten

Let me tell you about a man named Tim Aten. Back in my early days on this site, and during my brief stint as Week in Review, there was one man I could count on to consistently ridicule me in his columns. That man(child) was Tim Aten. If there was an invitational vote for whupping, Tim Aten would get it, because he was good at it. This is despite the fact that, at the time, I barely knew who he was, and had never said an ill-word about him, and never would.

Despite my cruel treatment at his hands, it is undeniable that he consistently puts out work of a high caliber.

If we're going to send someone to the invitational, let's at least get something out of it. Tim would give us a dense report, and that, to me, is almost the defining factor behind who I want to vote for. Let us not send another person to the invitational who is functionally illiterate. When the river comes, let us not turn a blank.

2. Mark Zajdner

Because you will not find a more earnest person on the Pro Tour.

Because Ken Krouner, Mark Herberholtz, and Sam Gomersall have called him the best teammate they have ever had, and North America's answer to Itaru Ishida in terms of Team Limited specialization, and I concur.

Because he took a Japanese refugee, Shades, under his wing and trained him how to moneydraft.

And because I'm sure Mark will know and will have played no matter what goofy formats they come up with for this tournament. He is a pure gamer, the man has multiple arcade machines in his house. He would crush this tournament.

And he's hilarious.

1. Jeff Cunningham

The pundits want you to play the numbers game. A lot of people have more pro points than I do. In the current season, when I have been able to apply myself, I have 13 points after two Pro Tours, which puts me in around fourth among the choices. I have 8 individual Top 32s, among them a Top 8, and several more money finishes, which I think shows a degree of consistent success not recognized by the top-heavy pro point system. More important is that fact that it's not just about points. It's about having an innovative approach, it's about the love of the game, and it's about having a personality capable of taking this event seriously.

And it's about writing a phone-book sized report, in which the author confesses to you every bitter detail, as if a teenage girl gossiping at a slumber party.

I am an old man in Magic years, quite likely on my deathbed. Consider this my make-a-wish.

It's up to you now.

- Jeff Cunningham



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